

Hymn of Breaking Strain

*He went over it in his head, plate by plate, span by span, brick by brick, pier by pier,
remembering, comparing, estimating, and recalculating, lest there should be any mistake;
and through the long hours and through the flights of formulae that danced
and wheeled before him, a cold fear would come to pinch his heart...*

Text: Rudyard Kipling, 1935, alt.

Music: Leslie Fish, 1983

BREAKING STRAIN 76.76.76.76.6

arr. Kenan Schaeferkofer, 2021

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1 The care-ful text-books mea-sure (Let all who build be-ware!)
2 But in our dai-ly deal-ing with stone and steel, we find
3 The pru-dent text-books give it in ta-bles at the end:
4 We on-ly of Cre-a-tion (Oh, luck-ier bridge and rail)
5 Oh, veil-ed, se-cret Pow-er, whose paths we seek in vain,

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1 the load, the shock, the pres-sure ma-ter-i-al can bear.
2 the gods have no such feel-ing of guilt for hu-man-kind.
3 the stress that shears a riv-et, or makes a tie-bar bend,
4 a-bide the twin dam-na-tion: To fail and know we fail.
5 be with us in our hour— of ov-er-throw and pain;

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1 So when a buck-led gir-der lets down a steel cas-cade,
2 To no set gauge they make us, for no laid course pre-pare,
3 what traf-fic wrecks mac-a-dam, what con-crete should en-dure.
4 Yet we—by which sole to-ken we know we once were gods—
5 that we—by which sure to-ken we know Thy ways are true—

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1 the blame for loss, or mur-der is on the ma-ker laid.
2 and pres-ent-ly o'er-take us with loads we can-not bear:
3 But we, of Eve and A-dam have no such lit'-ra-ture,
4 take shame in be-ing bro-ken, how-ev-er great the odds.
5 be-cause of be-ing bro-ken, may rise and build a-new.

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Oh_____ the ma - ker, not the made!
 Oh_____ too mer - ci - less to bear.
 to warn us or make sure!
 the bur - den of the Odds.
 stand up and build a - new.